

Blacks Solicitors

Complete firm and application research — programme details, culture, firm aims & values, sectors, CSR, apprentice day-to-day, awards, training and personal notes.

Route: Level 7 Solicitor Apprenticeship, 6 years

Location: Leeds

Application: CV and covering letter

2026 deadline: 31 March

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1. Programme Details

Level	Level 7 Solicitor Apprenticeship
Duration	6 years
Location	Leeds
Application format	CV and covering letter
2026 deadline	31 March
Rotation structure	One year in each department

2. Firm Overview & Culture

- Friendly and easy to get on with, with significant, genuine contact with the managing partner
- Opportunities to get to know colleagues outside of work — sports teams, parties, and social events
- Extensive online training for employees on topics including gender identity, equality and diversity, and sexual harassment — contributing to an educated, positive working culture
- Individuality and unique personalities are actively championed
- Mutual respect, with no real divide between senior and junior staff; honest feedback is the norm
- Everyone is described as approachable
- Lots of extracurricular activity — lunchtime seminars, and the ability to host your own "This Is Me" event to share personal passions and interests
- Staff can organise their own client-facing events
- Regular volunteering and fundraising events; CSR is treated as genuinely important, not an afterthought
- A green focus, including energy efficiency, supported by a dedicated "culture coach" helping embed environmental and cultural values day-to-day
- Open working spaces, including a dedicated wellbeing room — wellbeing and work-life balance are treated as genuine differentiators, not just talking points

3. Covering Letter Guidance

The application is built around a CV and one-page covering letter. The letter should cover:

- Why you want to work at Blacks specifically
- Why you want to pursue an apprenticeship route
- Why you want to study law
- Specific cases relevant to your interests
- Key skills, each backed with a real example

4. Firm Aims & Values

- Committed to first-class service
- Long-term client relationships are prioritised — the firm takes time to properly get to know clients in pursuit of the best possible results
- Operates a "four-hour call-back promise" to clients
- Continually strives for excellence and growth
- Recognised as the best law firm in Yorkshire for quality and client care
- A core value: doing what they say they're going to do
- Respecting colleagues and their opinions at all times
- Committed to recruiting and retaining the best staff in Leeds

5. Sectors

PRIVATE WEALTH & SUCCESSION

EMPLOYMENT

PROPERTY

COMMERCIAL

CORPORATE

RETAIL

- **Commercial:** terms and conditions, software licensing, sponsorship agreements
- **Corporate:** restructuring, due diligence, partnerships, investment agreements, share purchase agreements (SPAs)

6. CSR & Community

- Charity of the Year is chosen by staff vote — this year's choice was Leeds Down Syndrome
- Supports the Yorkshire Legal Support Trust, which funds legal aid access
- Runs a dedicated CSR blog covering ongoing community and responsible business work

7. Apprentice Day-to-Day & Experience

- Apprentices describe genuinely enjoying working with people and the social side of the firm
- Own caseload responsibility begins after around 2 years, alongside daily direct client contact
- Work is dynamic and fast-paced, with a wide range of tasks — drafting, advising clients, client meetings, legal research — and always something new to learn
- Described as genuinely rewarding; study is via BPP alongside the role
- Staying organised is treated as essential, given the need to juggle office work, lectures, tutorials, exams, coursework and a social life
- Encouraged not to be afraid of making mistakes — feedback is constructive, not punitive
- Advice from current apprentices: throw yourself into every opportunity, build connections across different teams, be approachable, volunteer for events, and don't be afraid to ask questions or leverage the expertise of others around you
- A "can-do," self-motivated attitude is valued, alongside self-discipline and determination
- Apprentices spend one year in each department during rotations
- Encouraged to sit in on as many calls and meetings as possible, and to learn actively from overhearing conversations and observing the wider working environment
- A strong support network is available throughout
- Business development skills are actively developed — networking and presentation skills, with encouragement to attend various business development events
- Core expectations: attention to detail, high standards of work, prioritisation under tight deadlines, strong work ethic, common sense, enthusiasm, and using your own initiative
- Philosophy of maximum exposure with support in place — supervision is available whenever needed, alongside significant client contact after the first two years
- Apprentices are expected to take responsibility for their own learning and development from early on

One current apprentice reflected they wished they'd known to ask more questions earlier, and to proactively ask to be involved in projects that sounded genuinely interesting, rather than waiting to be invited.

8. Awards & Recognition

- Legal Employer of the Year
- World Class Company to Work For, 2024
- Leading firm — The Legal 500
- One lawyer shortlisted for Solicitor of the Year, 2024
- Welcomed back two "returners" recently — seen as a strong signal about the firm's culture
- Retained 3 newly qualified solicitors in 2025; the corporate team gave a training contract and a solicitor apprenticeship to existing employees, showing genuine commitment to internal progression

9. Training & Progression

- Training is described as genuinely strong, with mentoring and a wide variety of matters to work on from day one
- A forward-thinking approach to training overall, with investment in people treated as essential, not optional
- Has supported a Solicitor Apprentice for 8+ years — one of the first firms in the region to do so
- 2026: 18 internal promotions planned
- Promotion rate is 7.5%, compared to a national average of around 4% — a meaningful signal of real progression opportunity for those who want to build a long-term career, rather than complete a fixed term and move on

10. Clients

Notable clients include BP, a telecoms client, Commercial Estates Group Ltd, Harrogate Water, Rudding Park, and Rushbond plc.

11. Recent News

- Firm blog coverage of Reddit's \$14.47 million fine, drawing out lessons for businesses on children's data protection
- Reported a surge in renewable energy work, with Power Purchase Agreements (PPAs) up roughly three-fold between 2024 and 2025, as property investors look to capitalise on clean energy opportunities — though it's an open question whether this pace continues given rising equipment/development costs

12. Personal Fit Notes

Space to develop personal talking points against Blacks' specific culture and values.

- The firm's "no real divide between senior and junior staff" culture and heavy emphasis on wellbeing/work-life balance are genuine differentiators worth referencing directly, rather than default statements every firm makes
- Given the firm's own internal promotion statistics (7.5% vs. 4% national average) and long-standing apprentice retention record, framing the application around wanting a long-term career to build, not just a stepping-stone qualification, is likely to land well
- Extracurricular organisation tools (e.g. Notion) and examples of juggling multiple commitments (sport, study, part-time work) map directly onto the firm's own emphasis on organisation and self-discipline as key apprentice qualities

Sources: lawblacks.com careers, CSR and insights pages; The Legal 500; Best Companies. Compiled as private research — verify current salary, deadline and programme details against the live listing before applying.